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Gov. JB Pritzker talks with a supporter at the Illinois State Fair in Springfield on Wednesday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Welch’s absence at fair clouds Democrats’ day

Scandals cast shadow over party as Pritzker makes case for another term

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Democrats celebrated their one-party political dominance at the Illinois State Fair heading into the fall campaign season on Wednesday, but their cheers fell against the backdrop of recent House scandals that have sullied their brand.

Illinois House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch’s controversial handling of former state Rep. Harry Benton’s sexual harassment of three women, including a former staffer, has left the chamber’s leader grasp-

ing to keep control and facing Republican criticism.

There was also last month’s indictment of 11-year Democratic state Rep. Carol Ammons of Urbana on corruption charges, along with her husband, Champaign County Clerk Aaron Ammons, a Democrat, involving state grant fraud.

For the actual Democrat Day festivities featuring party leaders, candidates and officeholders, Welch was a notable no-show.

An aide explained the Hillside lawmaker was accompanying his child to their first day of school. But Welch was in Springfield the day before for scheduled appearances that

included hosting a fundraiser for himself and making brief remarks at an Illinois Democratic Women’s event.

Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker — seeking reelection in November while also eyeing a potential 2028 White House campaign — welcomed Democrats to the fair by excoriating Republican President Donald Trump, saying “what he and his MAGA Republicans are doing to this nation is disgraceful.”

“By the way, this is the government that Darren Bailey rooted for. This is the vision that he and his Illinois Republicans want

See **FAIR** on Page A4

At least 10 killed in Israeli airstrikes

US had eyed restraint from Netanyahu amid Gaza talks

By Wafaa Shurafa
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — Deadly airstrikes in Gaza on Wednesday cast more doubt on whether new U.S. efforts can advance a tenuous ceasefire in the Palestinian territory.

Two days after U.S. negotiators reportedly asked Israel to draw down attacks in the Gaza Strip, at least 10 people were killed Wednesday in two strikes, according to local hospitals and the Palestinian Red Crescent. Israeli troops also crossed the ceasefire line in southern Gaza and detained a Hamas police colonel at dawn Wednesday, two witnesses and a Hamas official said.

Israel’s military said one of the strikes Wednesday, in the area of Nuseirat refugee camp, struck a Hamas commander who had participated in the Hamas-led attack in southern Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, in which 1,200 people, mostly civilians, were killed and 251 abducted.

A second strike in the Tuffah area of Gaza City struck another Hamas commander planning to carry out attacks against Israeli troops, the military said.

Israel’s military said a strike the day before targeted a meeting of four Hamas commanders and additional militants.

The commanders killed included

See **GAZA** on Page A9



Northside College Preparatory High School, newly crowned as the best school in Illinois by U.S. News & World Report’s 2026-27 rankings, on Wednesday in the North Park neighborhood of Chicago. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Northside College Prep slides past Walter Payton in list of state’s best

By Kate Perez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Stephanie Anderson knew her son Wyatt was drawn to Northside College Preparatory High School long before he applied and was admitted last academic year.

The school’s challenging coursework, student support system, athletics programs and size sold the entire family on Northside, she said — not to mention it’s a short bike ride away from their Bowmanville home.

“He always wanted to go there,” Anderson said of the selective enrollment Chicago Public School. “He’s always loved learning, he loves a challenge, and basically, when he went through the tour, my husband and I went with, (and) he just kind of knew it was the school for him.”

When Wyatt, 14, begins his freshman year at the North Park-based school on

Aug. 24, he’ll be walking into one of the best high schools in the country, according to U.S. News & World Report, which ranked Northside College Prep the top high school in Illinois and 30th best nationwide earlier this week.

This is a jump from Northside College Prep’s position on last year’s list, in which it trailed Walter Payton College Preparatory High School as the second-best school in Illinois and ranked 40th in the U.S., according to data reviewed by the Tribune.

Although Walter Payton College Prep took the top slot in Illinois and was ranked 32nd overall among high schools across the country in 2025, it slid in this year’s rankings, falling to 54th overall nationally and second in the state, according to U.S. News and World Report.

The annual rankings take into account

See **RANKINGS** on Page A5

Massive toll hike OK’d by 8-0 vote

Board levies 57% increase on cars and 30% on trucks, with more charges to come

By Marni Pyke
DAILY HERALD

A massive rate increase in 2027 with additional hikes every two years sailed through the Illinois tollway board of directors Wednesday.

The 8-0 vote means I-PASS passenger vehicle tolls will rise from an average of 7 cents to 11 cents a mile, or 57%, beginning Jan. 1. Truckers will see a 30% jump.

That will be followed by inflation-related increases every two years tied to the Consumer Price Index for all Urban Consumers. The CPI will be capped at 8% every two years, with a maximum CPI of 4% every year, officials said.

The increase is part of the tollway’s 15-year, \$26.5 billion Driving Connections capital program, which officials promise will reduce congestion, improve mobility and create jobs.

“Drivers rely on the tollway system every day, and their expectations are clear — they want a system that is safe, a system that is reliable and prepared for the future,” Executive Director Cassaundra Rouse said. “They want the tollway to address congestion, and they want the tollway to plan ahead rather than wait until infrastructure fails” or becomes a problem.

Numerous drivers have said the higher rates will force them to pay hundreds more a year at a time when other costs like groceries are skyrocketing.

“This massive one-time increase could have been delayed until the economy improves or at a minimum rejected in light of the fact that the tollway has seen its income increase at or in excess of the rate of inflation each of the last several years,” said Bill Morris, a former tollway director and Waukegan mayor.

Trucking executives were aghast, noting that unlike passenger vehicle owners, they’ve already been paying cost-of-living increases since 2018.

“It’s going to be crippling to the consumer,” said Mike Moran, president

See **TOLLS** on Page A4

INSIDE



EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Sox leave North Side on more upbeat note

Aided by Braden Montgomery’s two-run double in the eighth inning, the White Sox avoided a three-game sweep in a wildly compelling City Series with a 3-0 win over the Cubs on Wednesday at Wrigley. **Sports**

RESCUED IN KENTUCKY: Nine friends from the Chicago-area were saved by a search team along a steep rock face Sunday in Kentucky’s Red River Gorge. **Chicagoland, Page A2**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 80 L: 62
FRI. H: 79 L: 66
SAT. H: 80 L: 64
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A9
Arts & Living B7
Comics B12-B13
Crossword B13
Editorials A6
Horoscope B12
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A9
Television B11

179th year No. 232
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